In 1916, Lenin had himself tried to fill in some of the gaps with his work Imperialism, the Highest Stage of Capitalism. In it, the Bolshevik leader argued that the 'super-profits' the capitalist countries gained from their colonial holdings – such as India – had thus far stifled proletarian unrest in the West. Lenin concluded that any nationalist movements in the colonies should therefore be supported by Communists, in order to break the capitalist hold and remove their resources.[104] It was not until the 1920s, however, that this theory would be put into practice, as the steady gains of the Red Army in the Russian civil war gradually opened up Asia to Bolshevik influence. A key event in the evolution of Soviet policy towards this region of the world was the Second Congress of the Comintern. Founded in March 1919, the Third Communist International (Comintern) was intended as a replacement for the Second International, which had been denounced by Lenin and his regime during the First World War. Despite arguments by the Soviet government that the Comintern was a global political organisation, over which it had no control, it has been shown that the International's hierarchy was dominated by members of the Russian Bolshevik party.[105] Indeed, one historian has argued that the Chairman of the Comintern (Grigory Zinoviev) was a much more 'weighty political figure' than the Soviet Commissariat for Foreign Affairs (Georgii Chicherin).[106]

It was at the Second Congress of the Comintern, which convened in Moscow on 19 July 1920, that the relationship between Bolshevism and Asia was discussed in detail for the first time. It was here that Lenin developed his ideas from Imperialism to answer this fundamental question and effectively lay the foundation for all future Communist practice in Central and southern Asia. Discussion on India particularly dominated the meeting in July, largely because of the debate which ensued between Lenin and M.N. Roy – a well-known Indian Communist – on the question of the progress of Communist revolution in that country. While Lenin argued that, as a backward nation, India needed to experience a bourgeois revolution before it was able to progress to a proletarian one, Roy believed that the Indian workers and peasants were advanced enough for a proletarian uprising – with aid from Soviet Russia – to succeed there.[107] In essence, the debate centred on the larger issue of whether or not the Comintern should encourage Asian nationalism and pan-Islamism – how far it should support